



The ethical threshold should also rise for guests discussing trauma, abuse, serious illness, financial distress or other highly sensitive experiences. Explain the likely audience and permanence of publication. Do not pressure somebody into revealing more simply because emotional clips perform well.

Make sponsorship impossible to miss

A host-read advertisement works partly because it sounds like the rest of the show. That is exactly why disclosure matters.

Government influencer guidance says material connections with advertisers should be disclosed clearly and prominently, and recognises labels such as “advertisement”, “ad”, “sponsored”, “collaboration” and “paid promotion”. It also states that video disclosures should appear in both audio and video formats. ASCI maintains disclosure guidance for influencer advertising as part of India’s self-regulatory advertising framework.

For a podcast, use plain language: “This episode is sponsored by...” or “The following segment is a paid partnership with...”. Put the disclosure before or at the beginning of the commercial message, not hidden in the final line of show notes.

If a company gave you a product, paid for travel or provides some other material benefit connected to coverage, disclose that relationship when it could affect how audiences interpret the recommendation. Government guidance explicitly treats benefits beyond cash—including gifts, free products and travel-related benefits—as material connections that may require disclosure in relevant endorsement contexts.

Keep editorial and advertising decisions separate. A sponsor can buy an ad; it should not secretly buy your conclusion.

Be careful with health, finance and high-stakes advice

A disclaimer is useful, but it cannot transform reckless claims into responsible publishing.

India’s Department of Consumer Affairs has issued additional guidance for health and wellness influencers, including

WHAT YOU NEED TO DO

Create a folder called “Rights and Safety” for your podcast. Inside it, make subfolders for guest releases, music and media licences, sponsor agreements, source documents and corrections.

Next, create three one-page templates: a guest release, a pre-publication checklist and a corrections log. Test the checklist against your pilot episode. Can you prove you have permission for every voice, piece of music and third-party clip? Can you support every serious factual allegation? Have you disclosed every commercial relationship? Have you removed information listeners do not need?

The purpose is not to make podcasting fearful or bureaucratic. It is to make responsible publishing routine.

A microphone can make an informal conversation feel temporary. The internet does the opposite. Once an episode is downloaded, clipped, quoted and reposted, control becomes difficult to recover. The safest podcast is therefore not the one with the longest disclaimer. It is the one whose creators obtained permission, checked evidence, respected privacy, disclosed commercial relationships and made careful decisions before pressing “Publish”.

clear disclaimers when people present themselves as health experts or medical practitioners in relevant endorsements, and an emphasis on distinguishing personal views from professional advice and substantiating health-related claims.

For any high-stakes topic, identify the guest’s credentials accurately. Do not upgrade “fitness enthusiast” to “health expert”, or “market commentator” to “financial adviser”. Challenge miracle cures, guaranteed returns and extraordinary claims rather than presenting them as entertainment.

Where appropriate, tell listeners that the discussion is general information and encourage them to consult qualified professionals for decisions specific to their circumstances.

Create a corrections and takedown process

Mistakes happen. What distinguishes a responsible show is what happens next.

Publish a contact email for corrections and legal concerns. When a complaint arrives, acknowledge it, preserve the original episode and relevant production notes, and examine the exact disputed passage.